

Up to the challenge: Bortoleto will have his task cut out at Kick Sauber, the team that had the slowest car on the grid in 2024. Pics: GETTY IMAGES

the most competitive setups in the world of motorsport, with an ever-increasing band of drivers and limited seats on offer due to the senior team's success. Isack Hajdar will be the 19th driver from the stable to be promoted to F1 when he partners Yuki Tsunoda at Racing Bulls.

The path has been trod upon by many race winners in the past, including Sebastian Vettel, Max Verstappen, and Daniel Ricciardo, although a vast majority of the promoted drivers have now faded into oblivion.

Hajdar's entry into the big leagues comes after a closely fought F2 season, where he stretched Bortoleto to the very end, eventually finishing as runner-up. Hadjar, who is of French-Algerian descent, will be hoping he can put pressure on Liam Lawson in the second Red Bull seat, which had seen continuous rotation before Sergio Perez's four-year-long stay.

La Petit Prost (The Young Prost), a term given to him by the French media, will hope to outperform his much more senior and consistent Japanese teammate. One thing is for sure: the Racing Bulls race engineers are in for some fiery radio exchanges in the upcoming season.

Kimi Antonelli

Kimi Antonelli (**right**) may be the youngest driver on the 2025 grid at 18, but his journey to the top tier attests to the fact that age is only a number. The Italian is one of the few drivers to have taken the shortcut route to F2, skipping the preceding F3 league and joining the likes of Verstappen, Carlos Sainz, and Lance Stroll. It was seven-time champion Lewis Hamilton's exit that triggered an earlier-than-planned move for Antonelli to Mercedes. Team



principal Toto Wolff said on the *Armchair Expert* podcast with Dax Shepard, "I didn't want to miss out on him [Antonelli] like I did with Max [Verstappen] back in the day, [when] I didn't have a car [for him]; so that is all falling into place," said

Antonelli might have wanted his entrance to unfold differently, as it came on the back of a maiden F1 practice session that lasted only a disappointing 10 minutes. Taking eventual teammate George Russell's car out for a spin, his brief appearance showed some eye-catching pace before he lost control.

Finishing sixth in his first F2 season, he bagged two victories, three podiums, and four fastest laps but kept his head high amid tough competition. Although Mercedes does not have a track record for handing its car out to newbies, the Brackley-based team might have seen some unearthed potential raring to break through.

Among his first few tasks will be: making the most of a fluctuating Mercedes, keeping up with Russell, and not giving in to the pressure of filling the large shoes of Hamilton.

Raring to go: Hajdar hopes to outperform his much more senior and consistent Japanese teammate, Yuki Tsunoda.

